Eastern Europe just too difficult to comprehend. Again and again I read about the long history of violent conflicts in Eastern Europe, about a ‘troubled’ region, but I find it hard to think of any truly major conflict, before the wars in the former Yugoslavia or the Russian aggression against Ukraine. The history of this part of Europe offers nothing on the scale of the conflicts between the French and the Germans, or the British and the French or the various civil wars which have plagued Western Europe. There were no Napoleons in Eastern Europe before Stalin (except Napoleon himself for a brief period of time), and the nations of Eastern Europe have lived in relative harmony with one another over the centuries.

Before the twentieth century, wars in Eastern Europe were mostly fought with Russians, Ottomans and the ancestors of modern Hungarians; the latter came into the region after the Slavs and were soon seen as fearsome warriors. They populated a vast area, previously occupied by the Slavs, and were only finally halted by joint Slav and Frankish forces. If it had not been for the Hungarians, who ended up living between the lands of the Slovenians and the Slovaks, people in Western Europe today would probably be less likely to mix up the two nations. According to linguists, there are very important similarities between the Slovenian and the Slovak languages (although these similarities are not so strong that I don’t have to resort to English when I speak to my Slovakian friends!). Looking on the map, one can see only a relatively short stretch of Austria (part of the country which contains a Croatian-speaking minority) lying between the extreme north-eastern corner of Slovenia and the extreme south-west of Slovakia, confirming the ancient connection. (In fact, after World War I, the peace conference in Paris briefly contemplated the idea of using this stretch of land as a corridor, politically linking what were then Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia.[15])

Slav suspicions of Hungarians were reciprocated by the Hungarians. With Finns and Estonians as their closest and nearest ethnic relatives, Hungarians always felt like an isolated island in a Slavic sea, and they also felt threatened by Romanians and Austrians. Anxious to reach out from their isolation, they looked to the south, for access to the Adriatic Sea, and Croatia was indeed once included in their Kingdom. When Bosnia was annexed by Austria-Hungary in 1908, they tried in vain to have it for themselves. And it was Hungary which, more than German-speaking